

ANNA NAGAR

Purasawalkam » Villivakkam » Kolathur » Nazarathpettai » Pattabiram » Maduravoyal » Koyambedu » Tiruverkadu » Puzhal » Kilpauk » Perambur » Mogappair

Avadi » Ayyapakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills



THE LEGACY BEARERS

As India observes National Reading Month, a peek into two popular used-books shops in Chennai that survive because the women running them want to preserve what has been bequeathed to them, despite daunting odds **P4&5**



COMFORT WHEELS

Kilpauk resident P.R.M.M. Shanthakumar and his team are called on for assistance during bereavement and health crisis involving celebrities. His vehicle transported director K. Bhagyaraj's body from hospital to home **P6**

Parkour athlete 'stumped' by Anna Nagar signals

Vignesh Raghavan points out that the lack of a countdown timer at three signals on Third Avenue catches motorists on the wrong side of the stop line



PRINCE FREDERICK

Agility, balance and timing are pillars of parkour. And parkour athlete and co-founder of Chennai Parkour Vignesh Raghavan is not as challenged on the parkour course to deliver on those essentials as at three signals on his home turf in Anna Nagar.

The traffic signalling system at three junctions on Third Avenue

in Anna N, all three arriving in a succession, has left him stumped on multiple occasions, earning his traffic challans. One could expect this to irk him as he has become a collector of challans for no fault of his; and this has set him back by "Rs. 10,000 to Rs. 15,000 over the last two years."

And every time he rolls down Third Avenue, he battles the mental image of a challan dangling over his head. And obviously while

at the wheel on this stretch, he is on the rack, the ordeal beginning at the K4 Police Station signal, which is two streets away from where he lives, Q Block, 15th Street. Vignesh notes that at the K4 Police Station signal, Chintamani Roundabout signal and Shanthi Colony signal, motorists are challan-ed for overstepping the stop line automatically via the intelligent traffic management system (the cameras capturing a violation and the subsequent tinkle on the mobile). But motorists cannot but challenge the intelligence behind the system, as these signals do not have countdown timers.

Vignesh places the issue in perspective: there are the challans to worry about; but the greater concern is safety.

Without countdown timers, there is no telling when the signal would shift from green to orange. Vignesh notes that when the signal is green, motorists tend to assume there is sufficient time to cross the junction, but they are proven wrong many a time, as the signal turns orange and they have gone past the stop line. And the camera catches the "violation".

And this is how it impacts safety negatively. Vignesh explains

Vignesh places the issue in perspective: there are the challans to worry about; but the greater concern is safety.



At K4 Police Station signal on Third Avenue in Anna Nagar.

motorists aware of this problem either speed when the signal is green or slow down suddenly slamming on the brakes when they sense the signal turning orange, and both ways, they unwittingly become a road safety hazard.

Vignesh observes that as he keeps encountering this challenge at these three signals closer home,

he might be impelled to believe the problem is localised, but he is certain it must be cropping up in other parts of city as well, at any signal without a countdown timer where an intelligent, automated challan-ing system is in place.

He wants city traffic police to address the problem immediately as it has implications for safety.

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'Include East Balaji Nagar in S43 route'



The S43 small bus; and the service lane near East Balaji Nagar in Kallikuppam where residents are seeking a bus service. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.R. ILAYAKUMAR

East Balaji Nagar People Welfare Association, Ambattur, requests Metropolitan Transport Corporation to include East Balaji Nagar to the route of small bus service S43.

This bus connects Villivakkam - ICF bus terminus on Konnur High Road and Pudhur on

Ambattur - Red Hills Road. It covers Srinivasa Nagar, Teachers Colony, Lakshmipuram, Sarathy Nagar, Madanankuppam, Moogambigai Nagar, and Kallikuppam in its route.

East Balaji Nagar is a neighbourhood in Ambattur situated along the Kallikuppam service lane of Perungulathur-Puzhal Chennai Bypass. But the bus is operated via the main road of

Kallikuppam. If operated via the service lane in Kallikuppam, it will benefit a good number of residents of East Balaji Nagar.

Due to the lack of MTC bus services, residents relying on public transport have to walk up to Ambattur - Red Hills Road which is a kilometre away.

T.R. Ilayakumar is the president of East Balaji Nagar People Welfare Association

'Driving on Sterling Road is trying'



Sterling Road. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

TINAASHE MATHEW . H

Sterling Road in Nungambakkam is battered and marked with potholes for a considerable period now. This road badly needs a mending exercise. The uneven stretch gives room for waterlogging in case of rains.

The road has become narrow due to metro rail construction and

vehicles move slowly. The battered condition of the road adds to the inconvenience and slows down the traffic movement further.

There are schools, colleges, and hospitals in the vicinity and witnesses heavy traffic. Given its importance, this road should be re-laid at the earliest.

Tinaashe Mathew . H is a resident of Choolaimedu

'Restore key road in Manikandapuram'



Manikandapuram Main Road in Thirumullaivoyal. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

D. SURESH

Manikandapuram Main Road in Thirumullaivoyal is battered. Following a drain construction work, the road has not been restored.

This road connects CTH Road and Cholambedu Road and therefore witnesses heavy traffic. It may be noted, many of the interior lanes in Manikandapuram are good while the main road is in bad shape.

D. Suresh is a resident of Thirumullaivoyal

'CCTV cameras non-functional on NM Road'

BALA RUBAN

Most of the CCTV surveillance cameras on New Military Road (a State Highway) in Avadi are non-functional. They are also found dislodged from their positions. This has been the case for more than month. This section of the road comes under the jurisdiction of T6 Avadi City Police Station.

Bala Ruban is a resident of Avadi



'Area under Retteri flyover lacks maintenance'



The space under Retteri flyover.



T. GUNASEELAN

The area under the flyover at Retteri junction was beautified a couple of years ago. But some sections are poorly maintained and the plants have gone dry. Alcohol bottles and plastic trash are littered here. Some use the space to eat, sleep, and as an open public convenience. Also, the beautification work seems to be incomplete in some sections.

T. Gunaseelan is a resident of Ambattur

‘Pedestrians in peril on Madhavaram High Road’

Citizens forum seeks measures to decongest the road



L.KANTHIMATHI

Madhavaram High Road is known for bottlenecks and traffic congestion. This road, which stretches from Perambur High Road - North (near Perambur railway station) to Moolakadai junction on GNT Road, witnesses heavy traffic.

But the footpaths on the road are as good as non-existent. Hawkers and all kinds of commercial establishments are misusing the footpaths to keep their belongings. Further, vehicles are parked on the footpaths. All these compromise pedestrian safety.

From time to time, Perambur Neighbourhood Development Forum, a citizens forum based out in Perambur, has been raising this issue with the Greater Chennai Corporation but its efforts were to no avail.

As the footpaths are out of bounds, pedestrians are forced to walk on the thoroughfare and hence they are at the risk of being hit by vehicles, notes the citizens forum.

The forum identifies the stretches near the junction of Lakshmi Amman Kovil Street and Melapatti Ponappa Street and near the junction of Perambur High Road - North (near Perambur railway station) as the most vulnerable sections on Madhavaram High Road.

Metropolitan Transport Corporation frequent this road and schools are located here. Hence, the citizens forum wants Greater Chennai Corporations to take mea-



Footpaths on Madhavaram High Road on June 22, 2026.

asures to decongest the road.

“GCC carried out a drive this May to free footpaths on the section of Madhavaram High Road near Perambur railway station. Hawkers and the belongings of shopkeepers were removed. However, within a few hours they made a come back and occupied the footpaths. It may be noted the Supreme Court in a judgement declared a week ago states “freedom

to walk on spaces demarcated for pedestrians as a fundamental right” and this is an “enforceable duty.” Unless Greater Chennai Corporation takes stringent measures, scant respect will be paid to pedestrian space,” says Raghukumar Choodamani, the forum’s convenor.

A Greater Chennai Corporation official says the issue will be looked into.



Yoga celebration at school

KRM Public School celebrated International Yoga Day - 2026 under the theme “Healthy Aging.” Students, teachers, parents, and non-teaching staff took part in the celebration.

In his address, Krishnan Ba-

laji, Director, Sir Patanjali Maharishi Yogalayam Trust, stressed on the importance of regular practise of Yoga and meditation. He demonstrated a few Mudras that help improve memory, concentration, and other health benefits.

World music day celebrated

The courtyard of PSBB Nungambakkam reverberated with mesmerising tunes as World Music Day was celebrated on the morning of June 25.

Students, teachers and parents witnessed the programme, which was graced by the presences of Dean & Director and correspondent of the PSBB Group of Schools, Sheela Rajendra, principal S. Vasanthi and the chief guest, Sangita Kalanidhi recipient R. K. Shriramkumar, renowned musician and PSBB alumnus. The celebration began with a prayer, followed by a presentation on the history of music and the swaras from the music secretary. Students presented their renditions of classical music, a fusion band performance and compositions of the chief guest himself. Finally, R. K. Shriramkumar addressed the students, answered questions about his life and accomplishments and encouraged them to pursue their passions and do what they truly love and enjoy. The programme concluded with a special performance by the chief guest along with the school’s music students. The principal appreciated the performances and Sheela Rajendra spoke to the students about the calming influence of music and its ability to soothe the mind and reduce stress.

The celebration was a beautiful and memorable tribute to music and its power to inspire creativity.



Students encouraged to become ambassadors of ‘Say No to Drugs’



Students of Ethiraj College for Women at the awareness campaign. PHOTO: RAGU R

Ethiraj College for Women observed International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking with a massive human chain formation on Ethiraj Salai. Close to 3,000 students participated in the awareness initiative, which was organised by the Anti Drug Club in association with the Red Ribbon Club,

Rotaract Club, National Cadet Corps, National Service Scheme, Youth Red Cross, Citizen Consumer Society and Ethishakthi. Holding placards carrying the message “Join Hands and Change Lives”, the students raising slogans along Ethiraj Salai, which caught the public eye with their campaign against the menace of drug abuse and illicit trafficking, said a release. The programme was flagged off by V.M. Muralidharan, chairman, who expressed the institute’s support to the Government of Tamil Nadu’s anti drug initiatives aimed at building a healthier society. S. Uma Gowrie, principal and secretary, emphasised that awareness among young people is the strongest weapon against substance abuse.

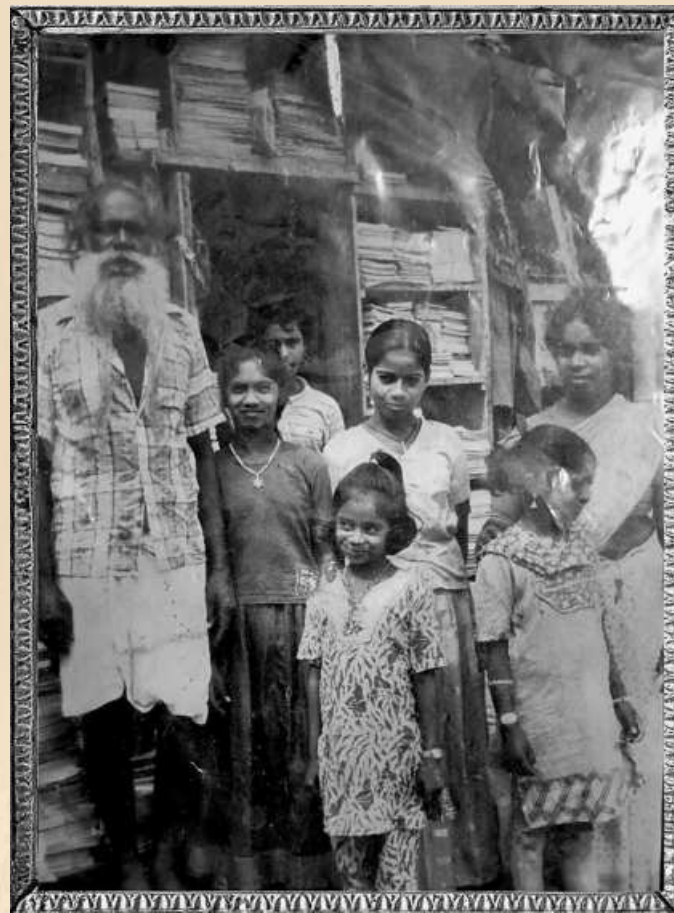
The legacy bearers

As India observes National Reading Month from June 19 to July 18, a peek into two popular used-books shops in Chennai that survive because the women running them want to preserve what has been bequeathed to them, despite daunting odds

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

R.K. Alwar did not want his books to be interred with his bones; and that was his final wish, not expressed on his deathbed but when he realised he was doddering towards it. Alwar's daughters Ammu and Julie have honoured that wish against daunting odds, ensuring the iconic Alwar Book Shop stays rooted to the spot where it has always stood at Luz Church Road in Mylapore. Alwar passed on in 2018 and since then his daughters have witnessed a parade of reasons to go back on their promise. If they had, nobody could have faulted them for it. The pandemic tested their resolve and the ongoing Metro Rail work has done the same thing. But these events had only ended up playing the devil's advocate, revealing to the world that this resolve comes with a cladding of steel.

Around Luz Corner and on this section of Luz Church Road, multiple retail businesses have trotted away in disappointment, but the duo has held on bound by that promise. Metro Rail construction has made Alwar Book Shop difficult to access, barricades and route diversions have discouraged many regulars from visiting it, and the once bustling pavement book shop is marked by a con-



(Above) Alwar's four daughters (from left) Eliza, Ammu, Julie and Lucy at Alwar Book Shop; and Alwar with his family.

spicuous lull. And changing reading habits induced by digital technology is queering the pitch further. But get this right, the daughters bear Alwar's legacy (which is their mother Ma-

ry's too; she also passed on in 2018) not as a burden, but as believers in it. There are believers from outside the family too. For them, Alwar's affable nature makes it compelling to believe

in his legacy and dream, which began in 1939. Ammu points out there are still a good number of customers best described as "loyal patrons"; they continue visiting the book shop because of their affection for Alwar.

The sisters take turns to look after the book shop both living just a stone's throw away from it for easy accessibility and for the unstated reason of refreshing memories. Family time has been around this shop. After marriage, Mary joined Alwar in managing the shop. Ammu recalls her maternal grandmother worked as a nanny at Good Shepherd Convent and, as a child her mother often accompanied her to the school, gradually acquiring English language with its myriad nuances. Though neither of their parents had extensive formal education, their love for literature was immense. "Our mother spoke English beautifully, and both our parents knew books and authors better than most people I have met," Ammu recalls in a tone betraying boundless admiration.

For their father, the bookstore was never merely a business; it provided him with meaning for existence; it was a dream he gave his youth away for. Ammu remembers how her father never spent a single night away from the shop and would brave torrential downpours to ensure not even a corner of a shop got drenched. She laughs while recalling, "He loved books so much that he would absent-mindedly call almost everything a book, even if it was a piece of cloth."

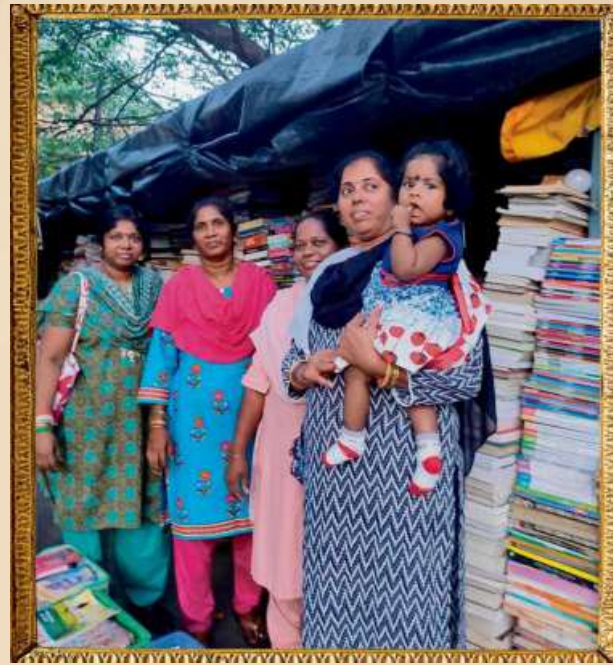
Perhaps the irony is the greatest story at the Alwar Book Shop is not inside any of those

thousands of books lining its shelves, and it is unwritten. This story is lived out every day by two daughters: returning to the same spot, made hallow by his father for those who worship learning and knowledge.

Ammu believes their father has never truly left the bookstore he established at this spot when he was around 16 years old.

Her voice choking and tears in her eyes, Ammu adds, "My dad is still here. We know he is. That is why we will never give up on this shop, even on our hardest days."

Alwar Book Shop, open from 10 a.m. to 7:30 p.m., offering fiction, non-fiction and academic books can be contacted at 9884773591



Scrap dealers probably do not warm up to old books with the same intensity as before; but surprises do crop up

The neighbourhood Kabadiwala as the bookseller

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Before the digital revolution, "waste paper mart" was a handy hanger for synecdoche the literary device. Old newspapers and books were always the unlikely bully in a scrap shop, elbowing even heavy metal scrap to the sidelines. In a bloodless synecdochic takeover, these fragile items proudly represented the whole of scrap materials. And the neighbourhood Kabadiwala invariably appended "waste paper mart" to their shop's name. Rajalakshmi Waste Paper Mart on East Coast Road (ECR) in Pallavakkam established 26 years ago mirrors this practice.

Its owner T. Ponraja is winding up operations at Pallavakkam, the shutters to be downed for the final time sometime next week, when he would be launching into his second innings at a new address in Injambakkam on ECR, carrying over lessons and scrap items, not all of them, certainly not the used books and stacks of old newspapers. He notes he is going to the next level, and reveals there is no room for old newspapers and books up there. "I will focus on wooden and metal scrap."

Even at Pallavakkam, the old newspapers and books were not raking in the shekels; a whole truckload of other scraps did that for Ponraja. But he would



T. Ponraja has lost faith in sale of old books as a revenue stream; and (below) Abdur Rasheed believes a demand for them continues to exist.



still display old books he received, on a metal rack right next to where he would be seated. He would not sell those books by a standard weight math, but by deliberate pricing of each individual book, turning over to see the price on the cover. He wanted book lovers to purchase from him. Over the years as smartphone models became thinner, the stacks of books coming in became correspondingly lighter. Good used

book titles were slow in making it to the shelf and slower still leaving it. He has spread out the last stack of books on the shelf. And these books might be waiting for readers that will probably never arrive. No problem with the quality of the collection; only that their time under the sun is up. "Even if I sell a book worth ₹499 for ₹100, there are no buyers," says Ponraja, believing the downward slide began during the pandemic, and is speeding as dependence on technology for information deepens by the minute. "There was a time when he would have a steady stream of customers looking for old books. Their enthusiasm motivated me to collect more books. Now, I have lost my motivation." This is a recurrent theme across neighbourhood scrap shops, many of them not drawn anymore to keeping old books for sale. And that contrasts sharply with how in the past neighbourhood Kabadiwa-

las headlined the chapter on old books in the circular economy. They would welcome old books jettisoned out of households. Sellers of old books would buy from them on the cheap, usually by weight; sometimes residents would be buyers, in which case, the price would be higher but still strikingly affordable. These books would find a cosy shelf in a new home and then again be offloaded onto a tricycle to be carted to a Kabadiwala shop.

While a majority of Kabadiwalas believe the death knell for the used books trade is progressively getting louder, do not be surprised to meet some who continue to believe in it. Abdur Rasheed runs a scrap shop at East Abhiramapuram First Street in Mylapore where a notable display is a wall-mounted metal shelf which is always populated by used books that are sold by weight, a fixed ₹80 per kg. Books might contribute to a negligible part of his income, but he still buys them as scrap, displays them prominently for sale. Explains Abdur: "There is still demand for books; there are still customers coming for books, because of which I go and fetch books. It is an amalgamation of fresh and old books, often both in good condition."

In this National Reading Month, such stories are a sliver of hope for lovers of printed books.

The bookmark shifted from a page of grief to one of growth

On Mount Road, Siva Book House tells a similar tale of loss, memory and resilience. Founded and nurtured by brothers Siva and Sundaramurthy in 1977, the bookstore located in a shopping complex on Blackers Road off Mount Road is now run by Sundaramurthy's wife, Malliga with the assistance of their son Maheshwaran. For nearly six years, the mother-son duo has kept the shelves occupied, refusing to let the bookstore become a forgotten chapter. A homemaker for most of her life, Malliga never once imagined she would one day run the very store she used to visit only to bring lunch for her husband, whom she fondly calls "my sir". It was Maheshwaran, their younger son who insisted the shop should not end with his father's passing and patiently taught her the

nuances of bookselling. She now travels across Chennai using various modes of public transport to collect books as per the trends; a routine once unknown to her now defines her life.

The store, open from 10:30 a.m. to 8:00 p.m., has a range that extends from magazines and fiction to non-fiction and academic books. Siva Book House was a prominent presence on the pavement on Mount Road just a dozen footsteps away from the Anna Salai Post Office. Overtaken by various changes that unfolded on that section, including the razing of a shopping complex, Siva Book House moved "indoors" into this shopping complex on Blackers Road. With reduced visibility, the bookstore thrives largely on the patronage of old customers.

"If someone urgently needs a book,

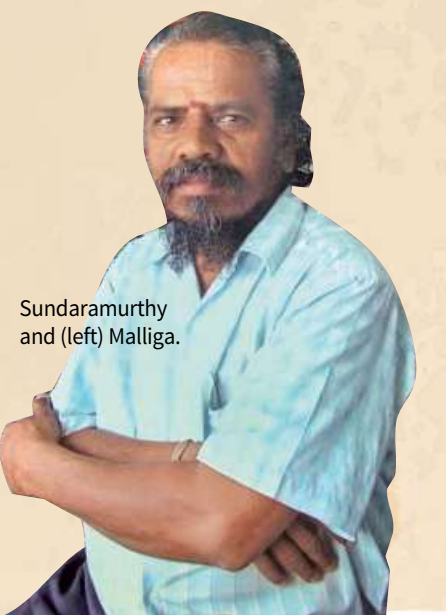
I will come as early as nine in the morning," Malliga smiles.

She fondly remembers how her husband handpicked every collection and occasionally took a young Maheshwaran along, unknowingly nurturing his love for books. Books entered Malliga's world through her husband's voice rather than the printed page. "My sir would narrate stories to me because I was not comfortable with reading any language," she recalls. "I may not have read them all, but I still remember every story he told." Though sales has declined with the rise of digital reading, Malliga believes technology can never replace the joy of walking into a bookstore, breathing in the scent of paper, and finding solace among the shelves. Their regular customers include teachers, government employees and media professionals.

Long after all the books on its shelves have been read, Siva Book House will have a story to be read, outside those book covers: the story of a

woman who stepped outside the confines of her home, picked up her husband's unfinished chapter and found the courage to keep writing it.

Siva Book House can be contacted at 9952934175.



Sundaramurthy and (left) Malliga.

Comfort wheels

R. RAGU

One can pass up an occasion for banqueting, but not an opportunity to be of help to someone facing bereavement or is up against a health crisis, their own or a family member's. In bereavement and health crisis that draw the attention of the wider world because of the personalities involved, P.R.M.M. Shanthakumar has made his presence felt from time to time. His company, Flying Squad Ambulance Service, which offers emergency medical, mortuary and funeral services through its fleet of vehicles, some of them massively high-end, has been called on for assistance during loss and suffering involving big names.

Shanthakumar points out that director the body of K. Bhagyaraj was transported in his company's vehicle from the Apollo Hospital to the deceased director's home in Nungambakkam.

Shanthakumar underlines that his hearse vehicles had been pressed into service for three chief ministers of Tamil Nadu, carrying their mortal bodies; they are V. R. Nedunchezhiyan (who was briefly acting CM in 1969 and again in 1987), J. Jayalithaa and 'Kalaigarnar' M. Karunanidhi.

Shanthakumar explains that in recent times he is also focussed on providing a plush space for people to carry out rituals for their dear deceased. Based on a public-private partnership (PPP), in which he has tied up with Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC), he is offering a cosy air-conditioned space for the performance of rituals and funeral service at the Jones Road burial ground in Saidapet.

A GCC official familiar with the development says a 1,200 sq.ft space was extended to him for the purpose. Shanthakumar notes the built-up area of the facility measures 2,400 sq.ft. The facility is not far from completion, and its inauguration would be announced in the near future, according to the source.

Shanthakumar has already

Kilpauk resident P.R.M.M. Shanthakumar and his team are called on for assistance during bereavement and health crisis involving celebrities. His vehicle transported director K. Bhagyaraj's body from hospital to home. In collaboration with GCC, he will be starting a funeral services facility at the Jones Road burial ground in Saidapet soon



A 5G ambulance; a funeral services facility at New Avadi Road and an upcoming one at Jones Road. PHOTOS: RAGU R. & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT.



established a similar funeral services facility at the burial ground on New Avadi Road. These facilities being established in collaboration with Greater Chennai Corporation are headlined "Dignified Farewell".

Sixty-five-year-old Shanthakumar, a resident of Kilpauk Garden Colony in Kilpauk, reveals that became aware of the lack of ambulances and hearses when he had a ringside view of how a day goes at an auto stand outside Kilpauk medical college hospital. His father was an auto driver attached to the stand, and a young Shanthakumar, in his teens then, noticed how bodies were being transported in autos for want of hearse services.

Shanthakumar lists among his company's achievements the introduction of a women-led ambulance service, private mortuary, funeral services and pet funeral services. He draws attention to "two state-of-the-art '5G Super Smart Ambulances', equipped with the latest life-saving technologies; each machine fitted with air suspension systems, ensuring maximum comfort and stability for critically ill patients during transport." The services are offered across India, he notes. Other highlights of the services include eight paramedical Professionals, three on-call doctors to accompany patients during critical intercity and interstate transfers; and 120 staff members tasked with patient care, mortuary management and funeral support services.



MOP, DG Vaishnav send most sportsperson for tournaments



The institutions recently won the Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy

in the men's section for the third successive year ((2023-24, 2024-25 and 2025-26), surpassing established colleges such as Loyola College and Madras Christian College.

"It was possible only because of the unstinted support from

our college management and our principal, Archana Prasad," said Amudha Sumankumar, Director of Physical Education at MOP Vaishnav.

Similarly, M. Karthikeyan, Director of Physical Education at DG Vaishnav, credited the college management and principal Santhosh Babu for the hat-trick of triumphs.

"We too offer free education to our sportspersons. Without the Management's support, we would not have been able to achieve what we have over the last three years," he said.

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

MOP Vaishnav College is regarded as one of the city's leading institutions when it comes to supporting sports and nurturing athletes. The college offers free education to sportspersons. It has also established a strong record in inter-collegiate and inter-zonal competitions, where it consistently figures among the top performers.

The college recently received the Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy in the women's section for hav-

ing sent the highest number of sportspersons to represent the University of Madras in tournaments across India. Remarkably, it was the 23rd consecutive year that the college had won the prestigious award.

MOP Vaishnav College won the Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy in the women's section while DG Vaishnav won it in the men's section.

While MOP Vaishnav continued its stranglehold on the trophy, the rise of DG Vaishnav College has been the talk of the town. The Arumbakkam-based institution has now won the corresponding award



Session on nutrition at Vanagaram school



The Alliance Club of Chennai Super Kings in association with Goodwill Trust organised a programme on nutrition and self motivation for students of Government Primary School, Vanagaram.

The event was held to mark the beginning of the academic year 2026-2027. Nutritious snacks were distributed, says a press release. Around 90 students along with teachers and parents participated.

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Building dreams

GRT Jewellers' scholarship programme to support 1,000 students this academic year

When Darshini first came across information about GRT Jewellers' scholarship programme on WhatsApp, she almost dismissed it as spam.

Recently, the B.Com student stood among hundreds of recipients at GRT Mahalakshmi Vidyalaya in Tiruttani, receiving support she believes will bring her a step closer to her academic goals. For students gathered on the sprawling campus, the Endowment Scholarship ceremony was about more than financial assistance. For many, it was a reminder that educational aspirations need not be limited by financial circumstances.

As part of its Corporate Social Responsibility, GRT Jewellers distributed scholarships to students in the first phase of its 2026-27 scholarship programme. Nearly 1,000 students, including both existing



Radhakrishnan, MD, addressing the students; and (above) from the event.

and new beneficiaries, are expected to receive support this year.

G.R. Radhakrishnan, managing director of GRT Jewellers, said the initiative reflects the company's long-standing commitment to edu-

cational empowerment. He noted that the programme aims to recognise academic excellence while encouraging students to dream bigger and achieve greater heights despite financial challenges.

The initiative was launched in 2021 and has steadily expanded in scale and reach. While scholarships remain at its core, the programme increasingly focuses on students from government schools, those from economically disadvantaged families, and other underserved communities.

The initiative now includes mentorship and academic guidance to help students navigate educational and career decisions.

GRT is considering constructing a women's hostel to provide safe, affordable accommodation for women pursuing higher education away from home, the release added.

Applications invited for best Tamil book award

Tamil Development Department of Government of Tamil Nadu has invited nominations for its annual award for best Tamil books. According to a press release, books published between January 1, 2025 and December 31, 2025 can apply.

Works of poetry, novel, short story, drama, history, linguistics, grammar, fine arts (music, painting, dance, and sculpture), biography, autobiography, history, epigraphy, archaeology, religion, spirituality and psychology can apply.

Also books on astronomy, mathematics, physics, chemistry,

engineering, computer science, technology, environment science, veterinary science, anthropology, sociology, geography, environment, geology, law, political science, economics, commerce, and maritime and trade can apply.

Books translated into Tamil from other languages can also apply.

Applications can be downloaded free of cost from the website of the department's website tamilvachchithurai@tn.gov.in and submitted. The last date for receipt of completed applications is August 31. For details, call 044-28190412 / 28190413.

ZIMSON celebrates Father's Day for collectors

Zimson, a leading multi-brand watch retailer, recently hosted 'Legacy of Time - A Father's Day Watch Collectors Meet' at V R Mall.

The event was jointly conducted by Zimson, VR Mall, Chennai, and Chronoholic India, an independent watch-collectors' community, bringing together enthusiasts, collectors, and luxury lifestyle patrons for an evening dedicated to horology.

Participants explored timepieces from Rado, Longines, Tissot, and Zimson, while exchanging stories, discussing collecting journeys, and discovering the craftsmanship behind renowned Swiss watch brands.

One of the highlights of the evening was an interactive watch quiz hosted by Karan Madan, founder of Chronoholic India, where participants were tested on their knowledge of watchmaking history, iconic timepieces, and



horological innovations.

Karan Madan said, "Watch collecting is about preserving stories, heritage, and craftsmanship. Events like these provide enthusiasts with an opportunity to learn from one another, discover exceptional timepieces, and inspire the next generation of collectors."

An interactive and insightful session with the audience featured engaging conversations about watch-buying journeys, ownership experiences, antique mechanical clocks, and pocket watch collections, said the press release.

Toastmasters club to meet today

Anna Nagar Orators Toastmasters Club is organising its meet on June 28 at Kailash Yoga Kendra, Y Block, Anna Nagar. Time: At 10 a.m.

According to a press release, it is the 100th meeting of the club and hence regarded as a milestone. The event will feature pre-

pared and impromptu speeches.

The event will be of interest to those who want to improve their leadership and communication skills.

It is open to all and no fee will be charged to attend the session, adds the press release. For details, call 87549 11095

Workshop on organic farming

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on organic farming in cultivation of vegetable crops on July 2.

According to a press release, the programme will focus on chemical-free methods of soil nourishment and pests management.

Also a culinary workshop on baking will be held on July 3. Various flavours of cakes such as coco, vanilla, and mango will be demonstrated.

Both the workshops will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048

Competitions for Krishna Janmashtami

Shree Geeta Bhavan Trust is organising the inter-school competitions on July 17 and 18 to celebrate Krishna Janmashtami. Competitions include drawing for children across classes, group bhajans for class IX to XII; solo song for classes VIII to XII, fancy

dress competition for pre kg to class VI, and Gita recitation. For details, contact P.Maruthi, convenor at WhatsApp number 9176624283/ S.Baskaran 9840770809 e-mail, gbhavan-trust@gmail.com, gandhian-gift@gmail.com

Yoga classes

Mogappair Panneer Nagar Manavalakalai Trust is conducting its monthly Yoga foundation course from July 1 to 13 at Seetha Kathi Salai, Fourth Cross Street, Mogappair.

For details, call 9840861519 / 9444418241

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